COLLAB COUP

MUSIC

RAPPER KING'S COLLABORATION WITH NICK JONAS HAS CATAPULTED HIM INTO THE INTERNATIONAL ARENA. HE'S NOW EYEING A GRAMMY



COURTESY: @XO.VISUALS

With his growing audience, King's **music has also shifted from a raw, bars-heavy** approach to a more accessible pop sound

Four years ago, Arpan Kumar Chandel was earning Rs 10,000 a month as a game attendant at a New Delhi Municipal Council-run sports complex, a job that required him to help people with basic workouts and exercise equipment. Much of his salary would go into his side hustle as an aspiring recording artist. The New Delhi native had been writing songs since he was in high school, and now—having dropped out of college, with a job that gave him both free time and money for recording costs—he was determined to put them out for the world to hear. Stardom, he insists, wasn't seriously on his mind ("the idea of a music career seemed like magic, and I didn't believe in that"), just a need to express himself through these songs that were bubbling out of him.

So, when Chandel—now better known as King—first heard a scratch demo with American pop star Nick Jonas singing on a new version of his song 'Maan Meri Jaan', he must have felt like an atheist who had accidentally stumbled his way into the presence of God. "I was a Nick Jonas fan since before I started writing music, so when [Warner Music India MD] Jay Mehta suggested a collaboration, it was like a dream come true," he says over the phone from Gurugram. "I went mad over the first scratch he sent, and I've been listening to the song on loop just waiting for it to come out," he says.

Released on March 10, 'Maan Meri Jaan (Afterlife)' marks another high in King's remarkable journey to the upper reaches of the Indian pop music landscape. Early in 2019, soon after he embarked on a project to release a new track every week, King was asked to audition for the inaugural edition of MTV's hip-hop competition show *Hustle*. He ended up making it to the show's final top five, becoming a household name with a massive